

Lava Banks on Open Source to Conquer Smartphone Market

Home-grown smartphone maker, Lava, is taking the small steps that it hopes will eventually lead the firm into the global markets. The company recently launched its Iris Pro 30 smartphone, marking its first foray into the mid-premium smartphones segment. **Hari Om Rai, chairman and managing director, Lava**, discussed the company's open source strategy and its growth plans for the days to come with **Prasid Banerjee** from **Open Source For You**.



Hari Om Rai, chairman and managing director, Lava

Lava has some really big plans for the Indian market. The company is currently focusing on building its business. It did business worth Rs 25,000 million in 2013-14, and has a target of around Rs 70,000 million for the next year. Hari Om Rai, chairman and managing director, Lava, says, "First, we are focusing on the infrastructure required to develop a product, then the infrastructure to build retail channels, and then marketing, and so on. We're building up the company to go to the next level."

Open source is the way to go

For all its future plans, the company is banking big on Android. Rai says, "Lava as a brand has grown on Android in

the smartphone market. The craze for Android in India is such that even a common man understands the ecosystem pretty well. People are aware of the latest versions of Android, and they want affordable smartphones with which they can leverage the app ecosystem. Android is the only operating system that can provide affordability because of being free and open source, and it is the only ecosystem that has a great collection of free apps."

Android is undoubtedly the most popular operating system. One of the reasons for its popularity is the ecosystem it comes with. Users get apps for almost everything on Android. Also, it is easy to use and has become the norm in the smartphones business.

And Lava, too, has gone the Android way—whether it is for the company's budget range of smartphones or the high-end Xolo series. Adding to the reasons for betting on Android, Rai says, "Lava is also very serious about the development of the open source ecosystem. In fact, we are possibly the only company that has started some unique initiatives for open source software developers. Lava is the only OEM in India that offers rooting support to most of its devices, officially. Users can actually root their Lava devices and take control of them."

The road ahead...

Even as Lava gets aggressive about launching Android devices in India, the company admits that there is a lot more that needs to be done. Rai says, "While the consumers are welcoming Lava with open arms, the company is preparing itself to deliver what is required. We currently have 783 service centres in the country, and aim to increase this number to 1,100 in about six months."

Last year, the company had 650 service centres, which has grown to 900 this year, but Rai says that the move towards 1,100 centres will be quicker. "The idea is to give consumers service that is closer to them and within a certain timeframe. We're looking at certain KPIs (key performance indicators) to deliver those kinds of services," he adds.

Talking about what he believes will lead to success, Rai says, "The number of smartphone consumers and makers